UNIVERSITY OF WESTMINSTER

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University of Westminster
University Research Ethics Committee

Application for Research Ethics

PART A

Section 1 – PROJECT AND APPLICANT DETAILS

1.1 Project Title: Explainable AI-Powered Legal Contract Intelligence System for Risk Assessment and Temporal Compliance Monitoring

1.2 Applicant Details	
Name: H.G.Piyumi Kavindya Wickramarathna	**University Email Address:** w1959641@my.westminster.ac.uk
Contact Address: 96/D/6/1,Veerajanapadaya,Uragasmanhandiya	**Telephone Number:** 0767300829
Faculty: School of Computing	
Please check the relevant box: **Undergraduate** ☒ **Postgraduate** ☐ **MPhil/PhD Student** ☐ **Staff** ☐	
I confirm I have read the *University's Code of Practice Governing the Ethical Conduct of Research*	**YES** ☒ **NO** ☐

1.3 Supervisor/Dean of Faculty/Faculty Research Director details

Please note that all applicants with a supervisor(s) must ensure that the supervisor signs the declaration at the bottom of this page if completing Part A only or in **Section 10.3** if completing Part B

All **staff** must ensure that their Dean of Faculty, or Faculty Research Director (or nominee), as appropriate, signs the declaration at the bottom of this page if completing Part A only or in **Section 10.3** if completing Part B

Name: Thamarasee Kapugamage	**University Email Address:** thamarasee.k@iit.ac.lk
Faculty: Department of Computing	**Telephone Number:** 0768209746

PART A (Continued)

Section 2 – Project Details

2.1 Please provide a description of the background with references to relevant literature (250 words maximum):

Commercial contracts increasingly operate within fast-changing statutory and regulatory environments, yet contract review remains largely manual and struggles to keep pace with legislative change (Senaratna et al., 2026). Existing AI-powered contract analysis tools can classify clauses and flag risk (Gangadhar, 2026; Prakash, Ramesh and Nair, n.d.), but they typically perform a single, point-in-time assessment and rarely explain a flagged risk with reference to the specific, dated legal provision that justifies it. Explainable AI (XAI) research shows that legal explanations must be actionable and contestable rather than merely descriptive (Mansi, Karusala and Riedl, 2025; Prajescu and Confalonieri, 2025), and that explainability carries direct implications for contract and tort law liability (Hacker et al., 2020). Broader XAI surveys further show that faithfulness and stability evaluation of explanations remain inconsistent across application domains (Saeed and Omlin, 2021; Longo et al., 2024; Kostopoulos et al., 2024). As a result, a contract clause that is compliant on the day of signing can silently become non-compliant once the underlying law or regulation is amended, without any mechanism to alert the parties. This gap, the disconnect between legal explainability, contract risk tools and ongoing regulatory change tracking, has not been addressed together in the reviewed literature. Publicly available Sri Lankan legislative and regulatory document collections, including Acts, Bills and Extraordinary Gazettes (Senaratna et al., 2026), provide a realistic, dated regulatory source that can be used to study this problem empirically

2.2. Please provide a brief description and the aims of your study (250 words maximum):

This study investigates an explainable AI-powered legal contract intelligence system for risk assessment and temporal compliance monitoring. The system performs clause-level risk classification on commercial contracts, generates explanations traceable to the specific, dated statutory or regulatory provision that supports each risk flag, and continuously monitors previously reviewed contracts to detect when a linked law or regulation has since been amended.

The aim is to design, develop and evaluate this system so that it produces reliable, legally traceable risk explanations and reliably detects temporal compliance drift, rather than performing only a one-off, point-in-time assessment as existing contract-analysis tools do.

The specific objectives are to: (1) critically analyse the limitations of existing contract-risk tools and legal explainability research; (2) define the functional and data requirements for the system; (3) design a modular architecture separating clause classification, explanation generation and temporal compliance monitoring; (4) implement the system together with baseline models; (5) evaluate classification accuracy, explanation faithfulness and stability, and compliance-drift detection accuracy; and (6) analyse the legal, ethical and professional implications of using such a system as a decision-support aid.

The study is a technical, design-and-evaluation research project. It uses only publicly available, permissively licensed contract and legal document datasets and does not involve any patient, clinical, or personally identifiable data

2.3. Please outline the design and methodology of your study (include details of the selection and recruitment of participants (if any) and details of any invasive (e.g. blood samples, inhalation/ingestion of food and/or non-food products (in abnormally higher or lower levels than normal or a different form), or intrusive (e.g. questionnaires, focus groups, interviews, etc.) procedures [attach extra information as necessary] (400 words maximum in total):

This is a technical, non-clinical computing research project and does not involve any invasive procedures such as blood sampling, or ingestion or inhalation of food, non-food products, or other substances. No biological samples or physiological measurements are collected.

The primary data used are publicly available, permissively licensed datasets: the Contract Understanding Atticus Dataset (CUAD), the LEDGAR contract-provision corpus and ContractNLI, which provide expert-annotated commercial contract clauses under open licences, and the Sri Lanka Acts, Bills and Extraordinary Gazette collections, which provide dated legislative and regulatory text under an MIT licence. These datasets contain no personal or identifiable information about living individuals and require no participant recruitment.

The core methodology follows a design-and-evaluation (design science) approach: a transformer-based model is trained and evaluated on the above datasets to classify contract clauses into risk categories; an explanation module links each risk flag to the specific, dated regulatory provision that supports it; and a temporal compliance monitor is tested using simulated regulatory amendments reconstructed from the dated version history already present in the Acts and Gazette collections. All experiments are conducted on existing, retrospective, secondary data, using document-level train/validation/test splits, with no live data collection from people.

An optional, supplementary component (Research Question 4) involves seeking brief, voluntary, structured feedback from one or two available legal or compliance professionals on whether the system's explanations are perceived as legally useful. If undertaken, participants will be adults recruited by convenience sampling through the supervisor's or candidate's professional network, will be given a participant information sheet and asked to provide informed consent, and will only be asked to review anonymised, non-confidential example outputs and answer a short structured questionnaire or interview. No sensitive personal data, health information or confidential contract content will be collected from participants, participation is entirely voluntary, and participants may withdraw at any time without consequence. This component will only proceed if separate ethical approval is granted; it is not treated as a certainty in the research design, and the study's core technical evaluation does not depend on it.

2.4. Timescales

Start Date (DD/MM/YY): 31/08/2026

Estimated duration of work: March 2027

Section 3 - RISK OF HARM

NOTE 1: Where indicated below applicants should check if the research will require ethical approval from a National Research Ethics Committee via the Integrated Research Application System (IRAS) - nres.queries@nhs.net.- http://www.hra-decisiontools.org.uk/ethics/
NOTE 2: The University of Westminster holds a Human Tissue Authority Licence – This licence is specifically for tissue stored at 115 New Cavendish Street in accordance with the terms of the licence – Advice must be obtained from the University Human Tissue Designated Individual (N.Presneau@westminster.ac.uk)

	RISK OF HARM (to self, colleagues, participants, environment or animals)	Yes	No	N/A
1	Will any pain or more than mild discomfort result from the study?	☐	☒	☐
2	Could the study induce any psychological stress or anxiety or cause harm or negative consequences beyond the risks encountered in normal life?	☐	☒	☐
3	Will the study involve prolonged or repetitive physical or psychological testing of human participants that may put someone at risk, e.g. use of treadmill?	☐	☒	☐
4	Will the study involve raising sensitive topics (e.g. sexual activity, drug use, revelation of medical history, bereavement, illegal activities, etc.)?	☐	☒	☐
5	Does your work involve any "relevant material" containing human cells (e.g. blood, urine, saliva, body tissues but NOT established cell-lines) from living or deceased persons (Such work must take account of the Human Tissue Act)? – See Note 1 and 2 above.	☐	☒	☐
6	Will DNA samples be taken from human participants (Such work must take account of the Human Tissue Act)? – See Note 1 and 2 above.	☐	☒	☐
7	Does your study raise any issues of personal safety for you or other researchers or participants involved in the project (Especially relevant if taking place outside working hours or off University premises)?	☐	☒	☐
8	Does your study involve deliberately misleading the participants (e.g. deception, covert observation)?	☐	☒	☐
9	Does your work involve administration of a food or non-food substance of a different type from or in abnormally higher or lower amounts than normal or one that is known to cause allergic reaction(s) or potential psychological stress?	☐	☒	☐
10	Does your study involve issues relating to personal and/or sensitive data?	☐	☒	☐
	PARTICIPANTS (and/or their records/associated data) Does your work involve any of the following:	**Yes**	**No**	**N/A**
11	Human participants in a health and/or social care setting (e.g. patients, those attending day centres, community care, rehabilitation centres, etc., including in the NHS, other public, private and/or voluntary sectors)? – See Note 1 above.	☐	☒	☐
12	Human participants who may be deemed vulnerable (e.g. children, people in poverty and/or with physiological or psychological impairments, persons attending rehabilitation centres, persons in easily identifiable positions that could be subject to victimisation, etc.)?	☐	☒	☐
13	Expectant or new mothers?	☐	☒	☐
14	Refugees/Asylum seekers?	☐	☒	☐
15	Minors (under the age of 18 years old)?	☐	☒	☐
16	Participants in custody (e.g. prisoners or arrestees)? – See Note 1 above.	☐	☒	☐
17	Participants with impaired mental capacity (e.g. severe mental illness, brain damage, sectioned under Mental Health Act, lowered or reduced sense of consciousness)? – See Note 1 above.	☐	☒	☐
18	Animals (or animal tissue).	☐	☒	☐
	INFORMATION TO PARTICIPANTS	**Yes**	**No**	**N/A**
19	Will you provide participants with a Participant Information Sheet prior to obtaining informed consent which can be taken away by the participant?	☐	☒	☐
20	Will you describe the procedures to participants in advance, so that they are informed about what to expect?	☐	☒	☐
21	Will you obtain informed consent for participation (normally written)? OR in the case of using personal data previously acquired was consent given for the reuse of the data for other research purposes?	☒	☐	☐
22	Will you tell participants that they may withdraw from the research at any time and for any reason without any impact on their care, service provision etc.?	☐	☒	☐
23	Will you give participants the option of omitting questions they do not want to answer?	☐	☒	☐
24	Will you tell participants that their data will be treated as confidential and that, if published, it will not be identifiable as theirs?	☐	☐	☒
25	Will you offer feedback to participants at the end of their participation, upon request (e.g. give them a brief explanation of the study and its outcomes)?	☐	☐	☒
26	Has external funding or collaboration been applied for/received, which requires	☐	☒	☐

	institutional ethical consideration or approval?			

Useful links:

- http://www.screc.org.uk/ - Social Care Research Ethics Committee
- http://www.hra-decisiontools.org.uk/ethics/ - Human Research Authority decision tool to identify if research needs National Research Ethics Committee approval
- http://www.nres.nhs.uk/applications/guidance/governance-and-directives/?entryid62=131341 – Governance Arrangements for Research Ethics Committees
- http://www.nres.nhs.uk/EasySiteWeb/GatewayLink.aspx?alId=134016 - NRES algorithm "Does my project require review by a Research Ethics Committee"?
- http://www.hta.gov.uk/policiesandcodesofpractice/codesofpractice.cfm - Human Tissue Authority Code of Practice
- http://www.hta.gov.uk – Human Tissue Authority website
- http://www.rsclearn.mrc.ac.uk/MRC_HumanTissueAct/player.html - Medical Research Council online training course for Human Tissue Act.

What to do next:

- **If you have answered NO to questions 1-18 (inclusive) and YES to questions 19-25 (inclusive)**, you do not need to complete the Full Research Ethics Approval Form (Part B). Please keep this form for your records, and do not submit to **Faculty Research Ethics Committee** (FREC) unless you require ethical consideration of your study, regardless of ethical implications, by an external body (question 26 has been answered YES). **A list of Faculty contacts is below.**
- **If you have answered YES to any of the questions 1-18 (inclusive) or NO to any of the questions 19-25** the Full Research Ethics Approval Form (Part B) MUST be submitted including Cover Sheet, Part A and Part B of the application form plus any required supplementary documents to the Secretary of the relevant Faculty Research Ethics Committee (FREC). **A list of Faculty contacts is below.**
- If you are applying for external Ethical Approval, please send a *copy* of the Conditions/Approvals letters to the **University Research Ethics Committee** (UREC) Secretary (this may include the original ethical application(s)). Where the external ethics committee/body has equal standing or primary jurisdiction, e.g. another University Research Ethics Committee or a National Research Ethics Committee, any approval will normally be received and noted by the University of Westminster Research Ethics Committee and further consideration may not be required. Where the external committee does not have equal or higher standing than the University Committee then the full ethical approval process at the university may still be required. Additional institutional compliance issues may need consideration by UREC.
- All Applications (dated, signed and authorised) and supplementary information or External Approvals should be sent to the University Research Ethics Committee (UREC) Secretary in *electronic format with a version number, document name and date and the Principal Investigator (or Undergraduate/Postgraduate Taught Student) name. On receipt your application will be issued a unique reference number*
- All new Applications should be submitted to a Research Ethics Committee (FREC or UREC) Secretary a minimum of 10 working days in advance of the Committee meeting date (earlier submission is recommended so that applications can be pre-vetted and obvious issues addressed before the application is considered by the Committee).

Contact details:

Faculty	Chair	Secretary
Architecture and the Built Environment	Professor Nick Bailey	Colette Davis
Media Arts and Design	Dr Anthony Mcnicholas	Fauzia Ahmad

Faculty	Chair	Secretary
Science and Technology	Dr John Colwell	Mandy Walton
Science and Technology Psychology Department Sub Committee	Dr Laura Boubert	TBC
Social Sciences and Humanity	Professor Marco Roscini	Victoria Grey-Edwards
Westminster Business School	Petar Sudar	Haydn Worley
University Research Ethics Committee	Professor Graham Megson	Huzma Kelly

For Use in Academic Year: 2015/16

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